began talking about his drinking and wondering how their lives might have been different if he hadn’t been a drinker. Then he told my mother that he had decided he was never going to take another drink, and she said, “Jack, how many times have I heard you say that?”

“Yes,” Jack said, “but you’ve never seen me do this before,” and then he disappeared and came back with a big jug of wine he’d hidden from my mother. Then he dumped the wine into the sink and smashed the jug.

She also told me Jack had started going to church again, a Catholic church near the house. As Jimmy Cagney described it once to me, “He’d heard the flutter of the wings.”

After I rushed back to California, Nelle told me something else I’ll always treasure. Back when the Rockne film was being premiered at Notre Dame, she had told me Jack, as Irish as you could get, wanted to be there, and I invited him to join us on the Warner Brothers train that took us to South Bend for the ceremonies and premiere.

Before he died, Nelle told me, Jack told her what the trip had meant to him: “I was there,” he said, “when our son became a star.”

Although Jack may have never completely defeated the curse to which he had been a slave, he and my mother had many years of great love together.

She rejoined him twenty-one years later, after years of torment by the illness we now call Alzheimer’s disease.